

CHAPTER 10

Stop Starting From Zero Every Time



1

INSTRUCTIONS

Source-backed step

example ↑

2

PROJECTS

Source-backed step

example ↑

3

DOCUMENTS

Source-backed step

example ↑

THE REPETITION PROBLEM If you use AI more than occasionally, you have encountered this situation: you are about to start a new conversation and you find yourself typing, again, the things AI should already know.

"I work in marketing at a mid-size UK financial services company. I write for a non-specialist audience. I prefer a formal-but-accessible tone. UK spelling throughout. Never use exclamation marks..."

This is not how a useful working relationship operates. A good colleague doesn't need to be reminded of your name and job every time you speak to them.

The reason this happens is that a fresh AI conversation should not be assumed to have dependable knowledge of previous conversations. Some platforms now offer memory, projects, searchable history, or connected sources, but availability and behaviour vary. Without one of those features being explicitly enabled and used, the context you built in Tuesday's session is not reliably available on Wednesday.

This is one of AI's most significant practical limitations, and one that is largely solvable.



THREE STRATEGIES FOR NOT STARTING FROM ZERO

STRATEGY 1, SYSTEM INSTRUCTIONS (PERSISTENT INSTRUCTIONS) Most AI platforms now offer a way to set persistent instructions that apply to every conversation. Sometimes called "custom instructions," "system prompts," or "memory settings," these are a set of facts and preferences you provide once and that AI carries forward automatically.

This is the most powerful strategy for regular users. Chapter 11 covers it in depth.

STRATEGY 2, PROJECTS ChatGPT, Claude, and several other platforms offer a "Projects" feature that groups conversations, persists context, and maintains uploaded documents within a dedicated workspace. For recurring work, client accounts, ongoing projects, regular document types, projects eliminate most setup repetition.

STRATEGY 3, CONTEXT DOCUMENTS When platform features are unavailable or insufficient, a context document you paste in at the start of relevant conversations serves the same purpose. A single well-crafted paragraph covering who you are, what you're doing, and what your preferences are can be copied and pasted in seconds.

A WORKED FIRST SETUP David runs a small consultancy and keeps starting client proposals from a blank chat. His first persistent-instructions draft is short:

I run a six-person UK consultancy. I use AI mainly for proposals, client communications, meeting preparation, and research briefings. Write in plain, professional UK English. Assume the reader is busy and commercially aware. Do not invent client facts, figures, case studies, or commitments. Flag anything that needs checking.

This does not try to describe every preference David has. It captures the context he repeats most often and the errors that would make an output unusable. After a week, he notices that AI still makes proposals too long, so he adds a default: lead with the decision the reader needs to make and keep first drafts under 800 words unless he asks for more. The instructions improve through use rather than through an attempt to predict every future task.



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WHY IT WORKS PERSISTENT CONTEXT DOESN'T IMPROVE AI'S UNDERLYING CAPABILITY. IT CHANGES WHAT AI HAS TO WORK WITH

WHAT BELONGING TO THE SAME WORKSPACE GIVES YOU When you work within a project or persistent environment:

Your uploaded documents remain available without re-uploading Your style and tone preferences apply without re-specifying Your role and context are understood without re-explaining Outputs from previous conversations can inform new ones Multiple AI conversations about the same work form a coherent body of output

This is a qualitative shift in how AI integrates into professional work. It moves AI from an occasional tool you use for one-off tasks to something closer to a working partner for ongoing projects.

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REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE Sarah manages a marketing account for three different clients. She sets up a separate Project for each:

Project: Hartley Financial, contains the brand guidelines document, a style reference email, a note on the client's preferences ("informal tone in client-facing copy; formal in regulatory documents"), the previous quarter's campaign materials, and a standing instruction that the client's compliance team must review any copy before publication.

Project: Meridian Retail, contains the target audience profile, previous copy that worked well, a note on what the Marketing Director has rejected in the past, and the seasonal campaign calendar.

When Sarah opens the Hartley Financial project to write new email copy, AI already knows the brand, the style, the constraints, and the history. The first draft is usable. Without the project, she would spend the first five minutes of every session re-briefing context she's already established.

WATCH OUT PERSISTENT CONTEXT CAN BECOME STALE. IF YOUR ROLE CHANGES, A CLIENT'S PREFERENCES SHIFT, OR A P



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